



Dominic & Partners

Audit | Tax | Advisory

Branches: Dubai, Abu Dhabi, Sharjah, RAK and Riyadh, Saudi Arabia
Suite B 3001, Latifa tower, Sheikh Zayed Road, Dubai
info@domuae.com | www.domuae.com | Dubai +971 56 6040 648 | +971 50 9801 263

3145738.161

MOHAMMED HAILS SYRIA'S RETURN TO PROGRESS

Vice-President expresses optimism over Syria's global standing

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, welcomed Syrian President Ahmed Al Sharaa in Dubai yesterday, expressing optimism over Syria's return to development and its restoration of the global standing it deserves.

Sheikh Mohammed received Al Sharaa, who was visiting Dubai yesterday as a guest of the Arab Media Summit, and stressed the close ties between the UAE and Syria.

"During my reception of my brother, President Ahmed Al Sharaa, I reaffirmed that our relations with Syria are based on the bonds of affection, friendship, brotherhood and mutual respect," Sheikh Mohammed said in a post.

"We rejoice at Syria's return to the path of development, and we are optimistic about Syria, the cradle of civilisation, regaining the global standing it deserves. We also look forward to deep fraternal relations between our two friendly peoples," he added.

Rebuilding its economy

The meeting came as Syria seeks to rebuild its economy, strengthen regional ties and attract international investment following years of war and destruction.

Al Sharaa, speaking earlier at



DMO

■ Sheikh Mohammed receives Al Sharaa, who was visiting Dubai yesterday as a guest of the Arab Media Summit at Dubai World Trade Centre.

the opening session of the Arab Media Summit 2026, thanked Sheikh Mohammed for the invitation and warm welcome.

"I thank Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid for the generous hospitality," the Syrian president said, adding that he was honoured to participate in the sum-

mit. He described Syria's transformation in stark terms, saying the country had moved from being a major problem to becoming a major opportunity and a potential source of stability for the region.

Al Sharaa said Syria had faced an exceptionally extensive sanc-

tions regime, with some restrictions dating back to 1979, and that the lifting of sanctions had opened a new chapter for the country.

"I believe Syria was born again after the sanctions were lifted, and the road opened before it. What remains now is policy, pro-

cedures, and making the right and sound choices," he said while speaking at the jam-packed hall with thousands in attendance.

Ambitious targets

He outlined ambitious economic targets, saying Syria's economy, which stood at around \$60 billion in 2010, had fallen to about \$20 billion by 2024 before growing to \$32 billion in 2025. He expects it to reach \$50 billion this year and return to its 2010 level by 2027.

"Our programmes aim to bring the economy to around \$200 billion over the following five to 10 years," he said, provided international conditions remain stable.

Al Sharaa said investors from the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Kuwait were showing growing interest in Syria, citing investments involving Emirati businessman Mohammad Alabbar and DP World's investment in the Port of Tartus.

"Syria has transformed from a problem into a zone of stability," he said.

Al Sharaa praised the UAE for being among the first countries to move towards investment in Syria, citing DP World and links between Jebel Ali and the Syrian port of Tartus as examples of opportunities emerging from greater stability.

The 24th Arab Media Summit runs until tomorrow at Dubai World Trade Centre, bringing together media executives, journalists, analysts, content creators and influencers from more than 23 countries.

SEE ALSO P4

MIDDLE EAST

Saudi Arabia, Egypt urge free and secure Red Sea navigation | P6

BUSINESS

New CBUAE rules target outages, cyberattacks and fraud | P-1

ENTERTAINMENT

Rhys makes Emmy history with two lead wins, genre trifecta | P13



Dubai shifts its focus from tourism recovery to growth

Emirates, Sharjah, RAK unveil new plans as UAE tourism looks beyond recovery

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai's tourism sector is moving beyond talk of recovery, with the emirate focusing on sustained growth as airlines and destinations invest in connectivity, infrastructure and new visitor experiences, senior tourism officials and industry leaders told *Gulf News* at Arabian Travel Market.

Hoor Al Khaja, senior vice president of international operations at the Dubai Corporation for Tourism and Commerce Marketing, said: "We're very proud of this city and the entire sector that really rose to the occasion to deliver such amazing results despite the challenges." She attributed the performance to strong leadership, public-private coordination and continued confidence among international travel partners.

Emirates looks ahead

Emirates' planned move to Dubai World Central is progressing in phases, with Dubai South's investment on track for



Ahmad Alotbi/Gulf News

■ Crowds flock to the Arabian Travel Market yesterday.

a target around 2032, Adnan Kazim, Emirates' Deputy President and Chief Commercial Officer, said. "The target still remains to be around the 2032," Kazim said, adding that Emirates is investing in "creating a new hub and new place" at DWC. The move will come in phases, with a major future role for Emirates SkyCargo, including a planned mega hub and terminal.

Additionally, Etihad Airways and Etihad Rail have agreed to explore ways to link air and rail travel across the UAE, including shuttle services connecting Abu Dhabi's Zayed International Airport with a passenger rail station.

RAK goes global

Ras Al Khaimah Tourism Development Authority and Emirates signed an MoU to drive visitor arrivals from selected

markets across the airline's network. The agreement will explore joint marketing, trade and media programmes and bespoke products for Emirates customers. The deal comes as RAK looks to strengthen international visitor flows and expand its reach through Emirates' global network. RAK is also expanding its mountain tourism offering, with Jebel Jais set for an 80km Grand Loop and a five-day Via Ferrata of up to 20km. The project will link existing and new trails and bring together hiking, climbing, camping, cycling and exploration.

Al Faya reimaged

And in Sharjah, a 1960s petrol station at Al Faya in Mleiha is being reimaged as a museum, alongside a former local shop and medical clinic. Shurooq CEO Ahmed Obaid Al Qaseer said the aim was for visitors to "experience and see, understand the history of the area". Al Faya Retreat is also expanding from five rooms to 20 accommodation units by Q4 2026.

Meanwhile, flydubai said it would retrofit 21 Boeing 737 MAX aircraft with lie-flat Business Class seats and larger overhead bins. The airline is also taking delivery of 11 additional 737 MAX aircraft in 2026, taking its fleet beyond 100 aircraft.

SEE ALSO P-II, III

IN FOCUS



WHY NUT ALLERGIES CAN BE DANGEROUS

Nut allergies can appear suddenly and escalate faster than families expect, with even a mild cough sending you to hospital | P8-9

Haj pilgrims, students to get flu shots

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

UAE health authorities have added school students and pilgrims travelling for Haj and Umrah to the priority list for flu shots this year.

Officials said vaccination is especially necessary for groups at risk of severe influenza complications, as well as for people who live with or care for someone who falls into a risk category.

Previously, the ministry's guidance centred on a narrower set of groups. The vaccine was recommended for everyone aged six months and older, but was flagged as especially important for health care workers, pregnant women, children under the age of five, elderly individuals and people with chronic medical conditions.

The UAE has also expanded its annual flu campaign to cover seasonal respiratory diseases this year, with health authorities asking two high-risk groups of residents, pregnant women and older adults, to get vaccinated against RSV, a virus that can trigger pneumonia and bronchiolitis.

SEE ALSO P2